

Ethical and Legal Concerns Reflective Summary

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When I began studying ethical and legal concerns, I understood that counselors were expected to follow rules, but I did not fully appreciate how emotionally complicated ethical decisions can become. The case studies made that reality personal. In one case, my values surrounding loyalty and friendship conflicted with my responsibility to protect clients; in another, my beliefs about honesty, marriage, and betrayal affected how I responded to a couple's situation. I noticed fear, anger, anxiety, and uncertainty while working through these scenarios. Recognizing those reactions helped me understand that personal values do not disappear when I enter a professional role. My growth has come from learning to notice them early, reflect honestly, and prevent them from directing decisions that should center client welfare.

Working through structured ethical decision-making taught me to slow down instead of searching for a quick or perfect answer. I learned to identify the dilemma, review the ACA Code of Ethics, consider autonomy and possible harm, consult laws and policies, seek supervision, examine different courses of action, and document the process. The cases involving confidentiality, impairment, boundaries, and competing responsibilities showed me that compassion and accountability can exist together. Speaking honestly with a colleague or client can respect their dignity while still protecting others, but there must also be a clear plan if the concern is not resolved. My legal research and mandatory-reporting training further reinforced that good intentions are not enough; counselors must understand their responsibilities and know when consultation or action is required.

I now feel more prepared to face uncertainty without allowing it to paralyze me. These assignments taught me that ethical practice is not about never feeling conflicted; it is about having a reliable process when emotions and responsibilities collide. I have become more aware of countertransference, the importance of boundaries with both clients and colleagues, and the value of supervision as a source of protection rather than a sign of weakness. I still expect difficult situations to challenge me, especially when they connect to my experiences or relationships, but I trust myself more to pause, seek guidance, and make an informed decision that minimizes harm. This growth has strengthened my professional identity and reminded me that ethical responsibility is one of the clearest ways I can demonstrate care for my future clients.